

One too many

AS SOMEONE WHO HAS TO REVIEW A LOT OF PC COMPONENTS, I END UP WIPING SSDS AND INSTALLING WINDOWS ON NEW MACHINES QUITE FREQUENTLY.

So I've become used to the entire process over the years and I've also seen how Microsoft's attempts to getting users to sign-in using a Microsoft Account has gone from simply showing users all the options that they can explore, to gently nudging users, to obfuscating options and making it very painful to remain disconnected. In fact, the most recent Windows 10 installations are so painful that if you've connected the machine to the internet, you'll barely make it past the first three steps in the setup process without being forced to sign in. And with the upcoming Windows 11 OS, they've invoked policies that seem to have emanated from the Third Reich. That's right, it's their way or the high-way.

To a large extent, they've made it difficult for users to counter this "innocent" requirement since they offered to upgrade all Windows 7, 8, 8.1 machines to Windows 10 for free. But that's not everyone. I've had licensed versions of Windows operating systems since the Windows 3.1 days and I've never liked the aspect of logging into my Microsoft Account. It was only after I absolutely felt the need to get Microsoft Office that I even logged in to my Windows 10 machine and I hated it because Microsoft automatically signs you into Windows if you log into Office.

If the sign-in process was a one time authentication process, I could stomach it. But this whole "being part of the connected ecosystem" is something I've never liked. And quite frankly, Microsoft isn't doing it because it's great for the users, it's because they stand to gain a lot by snooping on your behaviour. Google for Windows Telemetry and you'll soon understand the sheer amount of data being collected crossed the threshold of being ludicrous about five minutes past logging in for the first time.

With Windows 11, you NEED to have a Microsoft Account as well as Internet Access. Right now, Microsoft has only stated that this will be a requirement on the Home Edition but given how Microsoft tends to

shadily push for logins on Pro as well, I wouldn't be surprised to see forced logins on other versions as well. I hope that there's some GDPR compliant variant for the EU market that does away with this awful need to "stay connected". I will pay full-price for that version if I absolutely have to switch to Windows 11. It's not like I'm a luddite who doesn't understand the convenience of using a connected service that can retain your data in one place and make it accessible from anywhere around the world. I use Google's services for that exact reason and I'm very happy that all relevant and helpful services stay limited to the confines of a web browser. I can sign-in, do what I want, get what I want, give what I want to and sign-out when I'm done. And I don't get penalised or have a chunk of services cut off for signing out.

Microsoft is not like that. I have to sign in to use my Office applications, I have to sign-in to get apps from the Microsoft Store. Sure, there are workarounds and I've used practically all of them but at the end of the day, you have to submit. Having blocked every telemetry service I know of, helps me sleep peacefully at night but I don't feel that Windows 11 will afford me the same luxuries.

So when the year-end does come around and we get to see the final avatar of Microsoft's latest magnum opus, I might find myself staring at a fresh Manjaro or Ubuntu installation as my main system. The translation layers in Linux such as Wine have tremendously improved over the years and even gaming is no longer painful on Linux. A lot of publishers are pushing for Linux releases and even if I have to use an emulator, it's totally fine. I paid good money in building a very powerful desktop PC that's more than capable of running heavy applications within emulators. As long as there are no compatibility issues, it should run totally fine. Soon enough, my need for Microsoft Office will be abated, enough for me to permanently ditch Office and move all my work to Spreadsheets. All I know is that I will not be submitting to a garbage OS that's sole objective is to siphon off my data. Windows 11 seems one too many for my taste. **d**



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